

BRUSSELSTOMALBRANDEDIT

Travel Radio Australia and we're talking about Brussels at the moment. I have with me Tom Albrand from Visit.Brussels in Belgium and Tom, welcome to the program. Hi, good morning everybody, Visit.Brussels indeed.

I think we have a lot to offer to the Australian market from being the capital of Belgium, the capital of Europe, the destination to visit for the coming years and months. Really, the capital where you can find everything linked to Art Nouveau, to Art Deco treasures, to the Belgian gastronomy. Are we talking about beer, about chocolate, about the Belgian fries and the waffles? You know, I think that already gives you a very good mood to come and visit the destination.

Brussels is also its famous UNESCO classified ground plus, the Little Manneken Pis, the Royal Galleries. Yeah, really a destination that is booming, that has a lot to offer. Also, a destination that offers more connection from Australia, as we have new direct flights since last year with Singapore Airlines.

Also, added value with Catay Pacific. So, you see a lot of possibly connecting to the city and the region, the Now, tell us about some of your secret, not so much the really big touristy stuff, but there's some hidden gems that Brussels has and I'm sure you know about a few of those. Can you outline a few for us? So, the hidden gem, I think we started with the Art Nouveau and Art Deco treasures.

This is really the one that I would like to highlight. These are private houses that were totally renovated and now back open to the public. So, I would recommend to all visitors from all around the world to visit those houses.

Really, the Art Deco style is truly amazing with its specific urban work. The floral aspect, in fact, is all about bringing the outside of the houses inside of those amazing mansions. Really, this ancient time about a little bit of orientalism into the houses and how a high society try to profile themselves in those incredible architecture.

What about food? I mean, you've got probably the most famous chocolate in the whole world in Belgium and I'm sure that the chocoholics, and we have a lot of them in Australia, will have a good time. Indeed, Belgium is really a chocolate paradise, not only because of all the boutiques that you can find all around the region and the country. The chocolate is important.

If you want to know the story about it, in fact, so Belgian chocolate started ages ago when an Italian immigrant went to Switzerland to start his medicine study, but he didn't succeed into his medicine study. Then he decided to move to Brussels to open their pharmacy and he had a good idea to put chocolate around his medicine. You can imagine chocolate at a time the taste was awful.

It was actually an immediate success, so he decided to get rid of the medicine and to start a chocolate factory. And this is how Belgian chocolate was started. He invented the little praline, the little chocolate with a hard structure.

It's chocolate filled with something and his wife invented the little box, the little ballotin, and it was the start of Belgian chocolate as Jean Neuhaus. And Neuhaus is still a famous international brand linked to Belgian chocolate. But of course, you know probably Godiva, you know Leonidas, you know probably Laurent Gerbeau, Pierre Marcolini.

These are other big names that you will find back in Brussels. And you have, of course, the famous Brussels waffles, the Belgian waffles. Tell us about that.

Indeed, the waffle, another sugary, good choice. But in fact, there are two types of Belgian waffle. People always say the Belgian waffle, but yes.

So we have the Brussels one, the crispy rectangular, really plain, really soft in taste. And then we have the Leach waffle. It's more a waffle that you will eat on the go, that is a regular, that is rather compact with a little piece of sugar in it.

And I'm sure if you cross the street, you will immediately smell the very nice waffle taste of Leach and the Brussels waffle. Now tell us about the water tours in Brussels. You have a really nice water system there and people can get around the city and have a really good look, yeah? So when arriving on the cruise, river cruise to Brussels, generally we offer it as an extension to the cruise that you will do.

Indeed, to have the visit of the historic city center with all the classics, doing all the discoveries around, I don't know, the comic strip about the gastronomy that we just talked about, about the architecture possibilities. Also, what's brand new to the city is the Belgian Beer World. Actually, it was the oldest stock exchange of the city that was fully renovated and now back open since two years under the Belgian Beer World.

So impressive for the building and impressive for the visit, very emotional, very interactive visit about the 1,500 types of beer we have to offer in Belgium. Also, by the end of 2026, we'll have the pleasure to open the Canal Centre Pompidou Brussels. You probably know Canal Centre Pompidou Paris that we closed for renovation and then a part of the collection will move to Brussels with an addition of Belgian artists collection.

The people who come to Belgium on the cruise ships and it's a stop, you know, on the cruise, I suppose, down to the Rhine or whatever and especially a lot of Australians. I think you get a lot of Australians in the city too. We have indeed years after years more of Australians coming, so really glad about that.

I think it's because of the long-lasting history that we have in common. Also, I know that my

Flemish colleagues from Visit Flanders love to talk about Flanders Fields because of the tribute of the Australian people during the Second World War. It was indeed really something to remember, something we are not forgetting.

And tell us about a couple of your favourite restaurants in Brussels. I'm sure you've got a couple though that maybe stand out, that are a bit off the beaten track too. I think the very nice restaurants I would recommend Chez Léon.

Chez Léon is really the pure Belgian tradition when it comes to eat mussels and fries. In the surroundings or on the Grand Place, you have Le Roi d'Espagne, really returning back into the Middle Age with nice food and a very nice setting and environment, overlooking the Grand Place. Really a lot of possibilities.

Also opened last year back again Belga Queen, a very high-end property. Very nice choice to have dinner in Brussels. And Brussels is your jumping-off point to the whole of Belgium.

You can base yourself there and the transport links around Belgium are superb. Indeed, Brussels is really the starting point of your journey, combining a trip to the southern French-speaking part of Wallonia to the northern part of Flanders that is just Dutch-speaking. So really easy to combine Brussels with other cities in Belgium with the national SNCB, so the National Railway.

Also combining with neighbouring country, is it Paris, is it Amsterdam or London, with the Eurostar, the high-speed train. So I think in one hour and twenty you can be in Paris. So let's stay in Brussels and do a day tour in Paris and then come back in Brussels to enjoy all the neighbouring.

Now Tom, how can people find out more about Brussels online with your organisation? So please feel free to visit our website visitbrussels.com and also to join us on all social medias to stay in touch. Tom Olbrand from visit.brussels in Belgium. It's been fantastic having you on the programme and can you say a thing in your language for our Australian listeners, in French I suppose, yes? Indeed in French.

Look forward to seeing you in Brussels sometime. Thank you very much Tom. My pleasure, thank you.